km from Pune at Baramati and boasts around 30 Marwari and eight Bhimthadi horses. Familiar with Bhimthadi horses since childhood, Pawar says that while their presence was well-recorded in history, there was no recognition of the breed in government records.

His association with the All India Marwari Horse Society, Jodhpur, made Pawar aware of the need for a similar effort for the Bhimthadi horse. "I regretted the fact that despite their being a breed of horses native to Maharashtra and their role in history, Bhimthadis faced possible extinction," says Pawar. "Their numbers are on the decline as their use is falling. If no effort is made to preserve them, they will fade away."

Pawar first launched his initiative in 1996 and got Lok Sabha MP and actor Nitish Bharadwaj to write to the Union government. But then there was a prolonged lull, and it was only around five years ago that he revived his effort.

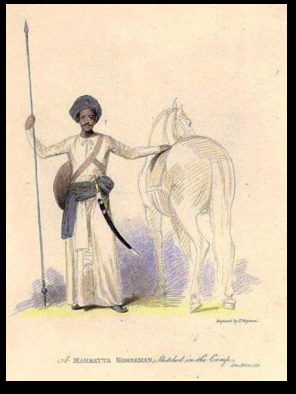
In his quest for recognition for the Bhimthadis, Pawar found an ally in scientists Sharat Mehta, head of the regional station of the National Research Centre of Equines. Mehta agreed that the Bhimthadis are "a good breed, very hardy, and could work to the optimum in the hilly terrains of the Deccan on less forage". Recognition, he too believed, would spur their rejuvenation through policy initiatives.

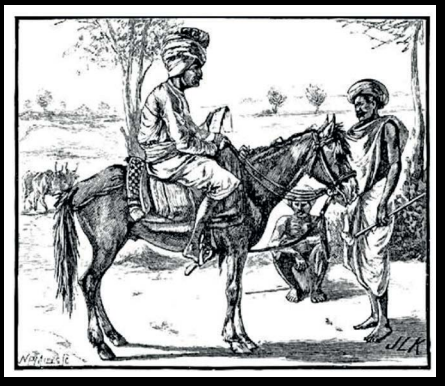
The actual work of getting recognition for the Bhimthadis took three years. India has seven recognised breeds of horses—the Marwari (Rajasthan), Kathiawari (Gujarat), Sindhi (Rajasthan and Gujarat), Manipuri (Manipur), Spiti (Himachal Pradesh), Bhutia (Bhutan) and Zanskari (Ladakh). The Bhimthadi is the eighth entrant. With the support of the Agricultural Development Trust, Baramati, a team was formed in association with the National Research Centre for Equines, Bikaner. Among other things, the process involved the collection and study of around 500 DNA samples from the Bhimthadi horses to check if they were indeed an independent breed and did not share DNA with other established breeds.

THE DECCANI HORSE IN HISTORY

ORIGIN
With its 'breeding tracts' in the basins of the Bhima and Nira rivers, the Bhimthadi/Deccani horse has been integral to Maratha identity, gaining prominence as the preferred mount of its cavalry in the 17th-19th centuries. The horse has been immortalised in the song 'Jai Jai Maharashtra Mazha' by the poet Raja Badhe. The line *Bhimthadichya tattana ya, Yamuneche Paani paaza* (Make Bhimthadi horses drink the waters of the Yamuna), speaks of Maratha supremacy at the height of its power

▼ A Maratha horseman with his mount, sketch by H. Hall, mid-19th century





▲ **WEIGHING IN** 'A moneylender on a Bhimthadi horse', etching by John Lockwood Kipling, late 19th century

REASONS FOR DECLINE
Disuse due to the decline of Maratha power, use of firearms and mechanisation of transport, preference for throughbreds and larger horses like the Marwaris, poor breeding practices and inbreeding

USES
Other than military purposes, Bhimthadis proved useful as pack animals given their ability to cover long distances on less fodder in craggy terrain. Currently used to ferry tourists in hill stations and pilgrimage centres. Prized for their role in bullock cart racing

REVIVAL
Its recognition as a separate breed by ICAR's Breed Registration Committee in December 2023 has sparked hopes of revival through adoption of good breeding and rearing policy and practices. The horses could come in useful for endurance and equestrian sports like polo and for training in equestrian academies

The Case for the Bhimthadis

The Bhimthadi may lack the elegance of a Marwari horse, says Pawar, but it braves hostile conditions better. Crucially, it can easily negotiate mountainous terrain unlike other breeds, which find going on downward slopes tough. Even-tempered and loyal, the broader chests of the Bhimthadis endow them with great stamina while their strong hooves do not necessarily require horseshoes even in difficult terrain. These qualities made them ideally suited for the Maratha cavalry, which was adept at hit-and-run guerrilla tactics in craggy, mountainous terrain.

However, its comparatively smaller size came in way of the Bhimthadi being recognised as a horse; officialdom continued to treat it as a pony. "But we showed that ponies cannot gallop at a